



to have vivid glimpses of Kerala's eclectic culture. The annual Beypore International Water Fest in December has created a new brand of water-based adventure besides evoking memories of the ancient maritime traditions of Malabar and the IPL-model snake boat race Champions Boat League (CBL) revived a zealously preserved village sporting tradition in a larger format. The upcoming Malabar River Festival in the first week of August will once again catapult Kerala as a premier destination for white-water rafting and water-based adventure activities.

Kochi Muziris Biennale, rated as one of world's prestigious artists' convergence, is as much about live painting and creative installations as about a pleasant, enlightening and educative season for tourists.

The tourism map of Kerala is now dotted with a whole lot of new locations in its length and breadth. Many a hidden spot that will never fail visitors has been turned tourism-ready. This has been done with the active involvement of local communities and self- governing institutions on the ground under the Destination Challenge initiative mooted by Kerala Tourism.

The state's Responsible Tourism Mission, the community-based grassroots tourism development project, has with its innovative initiatives ensured the participation of local communities in tourism while spearheading sustainability and ecological preservation initiatives and heritage promotion activities.

Kerala opened a new chapter in gender inclusiveness by rolling out the country first Woman-friendly Tourism project. At a time when women from around the world increasingly prefer to travel in groups of their own or solo, Kerala has reiterated its resolve of never failing them. Dedicated tour packages for women travellers are in the offing. A comprehensive mobile app to serve as a guide for them is being developed. One of the key aims of this project is to create a pool of well-skilled women tourism professionals who can handle a wide range of jobs in the travel and hospitality industry.

The state-run Kerala Institute of Travel and Tourism Studies (KITTS) recently announced new diploma courses and short-duration training programmes exclusively for women candidates covering an entire spectrum of tourism activities.

Youth participation in tourism sector is another country-first initiative by Kerala. As part of this, Tourism Clubs have been formed in college campuses across the state. To start with, youth power will be leveraged for proper upkeep and promotion of tourism destinations. This movement will also help mould skilled tourism professionals needed in large numbers in the near future.

Kerala is fast becoming an ideal Wedding Tourism destination as well as a buzzling MICE tourism hub. In April, the G-20 Sherpa's meet was held in Kumarakom, Kerala's backwater paradise. Deeply impressed by the scenic settings and the warm hospitality extended by Kerala Tourism as the local host, the international and Indian delegates to the conclave lavished praises on the state Tourism Department.

Kerala Tourism is a firmly established yet ever evolving brand. It never gloats over what it has already achieved but continues to strive to offer the best for tourists. Besides adding new attractions to its alluring assortment of choices, the state is working on a project to improve the physical assets of tourism sector in a sustainable and aesthetically appealing manner.

Also, to make a visit to the state an enduring one, Kerala will now offer a wide range of branded souvenirs made by its gifted craftspeople that bear the state's cultural imprint.

Come to Kerala, get refreshed and return home with enduring memories. The state will never fail you..



**Mattupatti lake in Western Ghats mountains panorama. Kerala, India**